
VI: Course Wise Content Details for MA (Political Science) Programme:

PS-CC 101: Key Texts in Political Philosophy

Credits: 4

Duration: 4 hrs./week

Course Objectives

This course aims to introduce students to select classical texts in Western Political Philosophy through two methods (i) an intensive reading of selected parts of the text, and (ii) by making them familiar with different interpretations of the texts. The idea is to instill in students an interest in reading original works, in the desire to closely follow the debates around the work, and to become aware of the different ways a text can be read. An academic session will offer a detailed study of any four texts from the given list.

Course Learning Outcomes

By the end of the course, students would be able to:

- Understand how to read and analyse the classics and use them to solve contemporary sociopolitical problems.
- Connect with historically written texts and interpret them in a familiar way (the way philosophers think).
- Present their arguments and thoughts about contemporary issues and develop ideas to solve them through logical validation.

Course Content:

Unit I: Introduction

- a) Why study the history of ideas?
- b) Theories of interpretation
- c) Meaning and context
- d) The importance of language

Unit II: Any one thinker

- a) Plato – The Republic
- b) Aristotle – Politics
- c) Machiavelli – The Prince

Unit III: Any one thinker

- a) Hobbes – Leviathan
- b) Locke – Second Treatise of Government
- c) Rousseau – Social Contract

Unit IV: Any two thinkers

- a) Kant – Groundwork on the Metaphysics of Morals *or* Toward Perpetual Peace
- b) Wollstonecraft – A Vindication of the Rights of Woman
- c) Hegel – Philosophy of Right
- d) Marx – Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844 *or* The German Ideology
- e) Mill – Utilitarianism *or* On Liberty
- f) Simone de Beauvoir – The Second Sex
- g) Nietzsche – On the Genealogy of Morals
- h) Rawls – A Theory of Justice
- i) Gandhi – Hind Swaraj
- j) Dr. Ambedkar and Women Empowerment

Essential Readings:**Unit I:**

Ball, T. (2004). History and the interpretation of texts. In G. F. Gaus & C. Kukathas (Eds.), *Handbook of political theory*. Sage.

Pocock, J. G. A. (1962). The history of political thought: A methodological enquiry. In P. Laslett & W. G. Runciman (Eds.), *Philosophy, politics and society* (2nd series). Blackwell.

Skinner, Q. (1969). Meaning and understanding in the history of ideas. *History and Theory*, 8(1), 3–53.

Strauss, L. (1959). *What is political philosophy?* Glencoe, IL: Free Press.

Unit II:

Aristotle. (2013). *Politics* (C. Lord, Trans., 2nd ed.). University of Chicago Press. (Original work ca. 350 BCE)

Machiavelli, N. (1998). *The prince* (H. C. Mansfield Jr., Trans., 2nd ed.). University of Chicago Press.

Plato. (1991). *The Republic of Plato* (A. Bloom, Trans., 2nd ed.). Basic Books. (Original work ca. 380 BCE)

Unit III:

Hobbes, T. (1968). *Leviathan* (C. B. Macpherson, Ed.). Penguin Books. (Original work published 1651)

Locke, J. (1980). *Second treatise of government* (C. B. Macpherson, Ed.). Hackett Publishing. (Original work published 1689)

Rousseau, J.-J. (1978). *On the social contract: With Geneva manuscript and political*

economy (R. D. Masters, Ed. & J. R. Masters, Trans.). St. Martin's Press. (Original work published 1762)

Unit IV:

Ambedkar, B. R. (1936). *The Woman and the CounterRevolution*. In V. Moon (Ed.), *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar: Writings and Speeches* (Vol. 3, pp. 429–437). Bombay: Education Department, Government of Maharashtra. (Reprinted from *Mook Nayak*)

Beauvoir, S. de. (1984). *The second sex* (H. M. Pashley, Trans.). Penguin. (Original work published 1949)

Gandhi, M. K. *Hind Swaraj and Other Writings*. Ed. By Anthony Parel. Cambridge University Press, 1997.

Hegel, G. W. F. (1942). *The philosophy of right* (T. M. Knox, Trans.). Clarendon Press

Kant, I. (1991). From the critique of pure reason to perpetual peace. In H. Reiss (Ed.), *Kant: Political writings* (2nd ed., pp. 93–175) (H. B. Nisbet, Trans.). Cambridge University Press.

Mill, J. S. (1991). *On liberty and other essays* (J. Gray, Ed.). Oxford University Press. (Original work published 1859)

Nietzsche, F. (1967). *On the genealogy of morals and Ecce Homo* (W. Kaufmann & R. J. Hollingdale, Trans.). Vintage Books.

Rawls, J. (1971). *A theory of justice*. Harvard University Press.

Tucker, R. C. (Ed.). (1978). *The Marx-Engels reader* (2nd ed.). W. W. Norton & Co.

Wollstonecraft, M. (1993). A vindication of the rights of woman. In J. Todd (Ed.), *Wollstonecraft: Political writings* (pp. 67–296). University of Toronto Press. (Original work published 1792)

Facilitating the achievement of Course Learning Outcomes:

The Department deploys multiple methods to evaluate the program outcomes alongside the stipulated requirements of the university to have internal assessments and end-of-semester exams. The communication and analytical skills of students are evaluated through regular class presentations and group discussions.